

NFL Innovation HUB

Establishing Formal Governance & Structure

*Executive Steering Committee
January 2026*



Executive Summary

THE PROBLEM

Projects entering and exiting the HUB without formal approval gates, creating resource churn and burning through allocated hours with limited visibility into scope, roles, or outcomes.

THE IMPACT

12+ projects tracked in the past 12 months with unclear scope, roles, and boundaries. Significant NFL stakeholder time invested with inconsistent outcomes and limited ability to measure return on investment.

THE SOLUTION

- **Formalize the 3-Model Program Structure**

Innovation Challenges, Co-Create Programs, and Operationalization & Change Management

- **Implement Mandatory Intake & Approval Process**

Stage gates with NFL stakeholder sign-off before resource allocation

- **Establish Clear Roles & Responsibilities**

NFL approves intake and prioritization; NOVATE manages execution; defined boundaries with vendors

The Problem: Uncontrolled Project Churn

12 Months of Project Activity (January 2025 – January 2026)

Coach to Player (C2P)	Testing	4	touchpoints	● ● ● ●
Agentic AI for IT Operations	Discovery	2	touchpoints	● ●
AI at Scale	Planning	2	touchpoints	● ●
Amazon Player Tracking Sensors	Use Cases	1	touchpoints	●
OnePass Innovation Challenge	RFI/Demos	6	touchpoints	● ● ● ● ● ●
Generative AI (Adobe)	Execution	6	touchpoints	● ● ● ● ● ●
Multimodal AI for Broadcast Compliance	Proposal	1	touchpoints	●
Rypplzz (International Fan Engagement)	Concept	1	touchpoints	●
Digital Signage	Analysis	6	touchpoints	● ● ● ● ● ●

No formal intake process • No approval gates • No resource allocation controls

The Impact: Resource Allocation Without Visibility

12+

Projects Tracked
in the past 12 months

4.3

Avg. Touchpoints
per project

UNKNOWN

Resource Utilization
no tracking mechanism

HIGH

Stakeholder Time
inconsistent engagement

CONSEQUENCES

- **Partial Visibility:** Projects enter HUB through informal channels without documented scope or success criteria
- **Limited NFL Participation:** Unclear stakeholder engagement leads to misaligned expectations and delayed decisions
- **Unclear Vendor Boundaries:** No defined protocols for when/how to engage NFL vendors creates confusion and potential conflicts
- **Resource Burn:** NOVATE hours consumed on undefined scope without strategic prioritization

Root Cause: Missing Governance Framework

The 2025 Program Design exists but is not being enforced

DESIGNED STRUCTURE

3-Model Program:

- Innovation Challenges
- Co-Create Programs
- Operationalization

Stage Gate Process:

- Intake → Concept → Business Case
- MVP → ROI → Grow

Clear Governance:

- Executive Steering Committee
- Program Execution Committee
- NFL approvals required

CURRENT REALITY

- Projects bypass intake
- No formal approval process
- Unclear which model applies
- Stage gates not enforced
- Resource allocation ad hoc
- Limited executive visibility

REQUIRED ACTIONS

- Mandate intake process
- Activate stage gates
- Define approval authority
- Establish project classification
- Implement tracking system
- Monthly governance reviews

The Designed Structure: 3-Model Program

2025 Program Design defines three engagement models—we need to enforce them

Model 1: NFL Innovation Challenges

Curated end-to-end pipeline for sourcing, testing, and scaling high-impact innovations. Multi-phase process with league stakeholder champions. Co-funded by league departments.

Model 2: NFL Co-Create Program

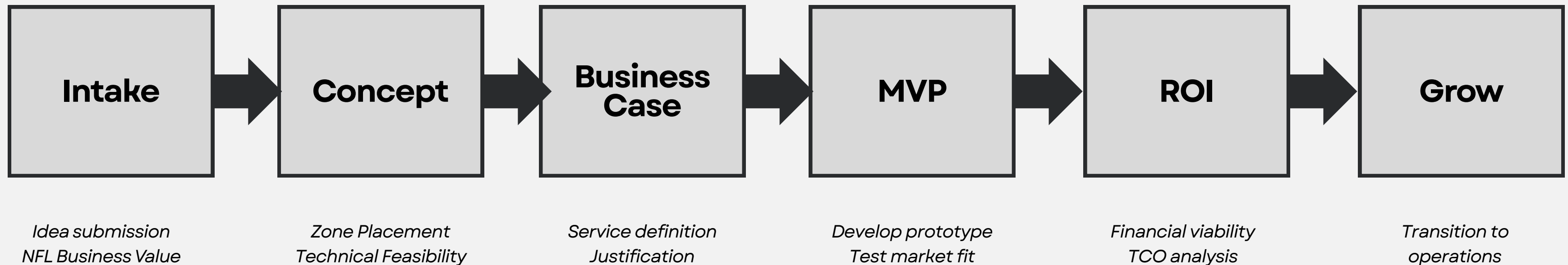
Partner-driven innovation with sponsors and approved partners. Includes Sponsored POC Track and Partner-Funded Co-Create. All sponsor communications coordinated with NFL Sponsorship.

Model 3: Operationalization & Change Management

Apply HUB infrastructure to internal priorities through R&D, prototyping, and rapid launch capabilities. Internal tech integrations and POCs impacting multiple departments.

Stage Gate Process: Required Approvals

Every project must progress through defined stages with NFL approval



Approval Authority of Each Gate

- Stage 1–2 (Intake/Concept): Program Execution Committee review • NFL sponsor identified
- Stage 3 (Business Case): SVP approval required • Resource allocation approved
- Stage 4–5 (MVP/ROI): Quarterly reviews with Program Execution Committee
- Stage 6 (Grow): Executive Steering Committee approval for operationalization

Governance Structure: Decision Rights

Executive Steering Committee

EVPs • Strategic direction • Annual priorities

Program Execution Committee

SVPs from IT, Player Health & Safety, Football Ops, Media, Data & Analytics, Finance, Sponsorship

Innovation Tech Advisory Committee

NFL Technical Working Group • Subject matter experts • Technical evaluation

Innovation HUB PMO (NOVATE) — Intake, Prioritization & Program Management

Roles & Responsibilities: Clear Boundaries

NFL Responsibilities

- Approve project intake and prioritization
- Provide internal stakeholder and tech access
- Align funding and timelines via governance cadence
- Stage gate approvals at Business Case, MVP, and Grow phases
- Define success criteria and measurement

NOVATE Responsibilities

- Program Director + Ops Analyst (Core team)
- Intake & blueprinting management
- R&D delivery via Innovation Pods and NIN Partner Network
- Internal knowledge hub (EVERGAME + Sentrais)
- All projects tagged and tracked by zone, model, phase

Vendor Engagement: Defined Protocols

Clear boundaries for when and how to engage with NFL vendors

Scenario 1: Innovation Challenge — External Vendors

NOVATE sources, evaluates, and manages external vendors. NFL approves finalists. No engagement with existing NFL vendors unless explicitly approved by NFL leadership.

Scenario 2: Co-Create — Sponsor/Partner Vendors

All sponsor communications coordinated with NFL Sponsorship. Partner-funded POCs require Steering Committee approval. RACI matrix defines engagement boundaries upfront.

Scenario 3: Operationalization — Existing NFL Vendors

NOVATE acts as R&D resource to IT/BRM functions. NFL retains all vendor relationships. NOVATE provides technical blueprints and recommendations only—no direct vendor engagement without NFL approval.

Key Principle: NFL retains all decision-making authority on vendor relationships. NOVATE provides evaluation framework and recommendations. All vendor engagements require documented NFL approval before initiation.

Mandatory Intake Process

All projects must enter through formal intake—no exceptions

1	Submit Intake Form	Lean canvas questionnaire Business value justification
2	Initial Triage	NOVATE PMO reviews Assigns to model category
3	Committee Review	Program Exec Committee Approves or rejects
4	Resource Allocation	If approved, resources assigned Project kickoff scheduled
5	Tracking Initiated	Sentraais tagging Monthly governance reviews

Tracking & Visibility: Sentrais Integration

Every project tagged and tracked in real-time

Tagging Taxonomy: [ZONE]–[MODEL]–[NIN PHASE]–[STATUS]

Example: TRANSFORMATION–CHALLENGE–P3–ACTIVE

ZONE

Incubation
Transformation
Performance
Productivity

MODELS

Challenge
Co-Create
Operationalization

NIN PHASES

P1: Discovery
P2: Blueprinting
P3: Innovation
P4: Pilot
P5: Operationalization
P6: Iteration

Resource Management: Defined Allocation

Projects are outcome-bound with defined runway and resourcing

Each project defines:

- Estimated Hours: Range-based allocation (e.g., 40–60 hrs for Discovery phase)
- Timeline: Defined runway with milestones and decision points
- Scope: Clear deliverables and success criteria documented upfront
- Stop Conditions: Criteria for project pause, pivot, or termination
- ROI Metrics: Defined success measures for NFL and partners

Avoiding Churn: No project moves forward without approved scope, timeline, and resource allocation

Implementation Roadmap

60-Day Plan to Formalize Governance

Immediate (Week 1-2)

1. Steering Committee approval of governance framework
2. Communicate new intake requirements to all stakeholders
3. Audit all current projects and classify by model
4. Retroactively document scope for active projects

Short-Term (Week 3-4)

1. Implement intake form and approval workflow
2. Establish monthly governance review cadence
3. Deploy Sentrais tagging for all projects
4. Create vendor engagement protocol documentation

Sustained (Week 5-8)

1. First monthly dashboard review
2. Enforce stage gate approvals on all new projects
3. Measure resource utilization and adjust
4. Continuous improvement based on feedback

Success Metrics: Measuring Governance Impact

How we'll know the governance framework is working

100%

Intake Compliance

All new projects enter through formal intake process

Monthly

Dashboard Reviews

Program Exec Committee receives project status updates

Full

Project Visibility

Real-time tracking of all HUB projects in Sentrais

≥75%

Resource Efficiency

NOVATE hours allocated to approved, scoped projects

Clear

Vendor Boundaries

Documented protocols followed on all engagements

Defined

Success Criteria

Every project has measurable outcomes

Decision Required

*Approve formalized governance framework
and mandatory intake process*

Without proper governance:

- Project churn will continue unabated
- Resource allocation remains uncontrolled
- NFL stakeholder time continues to be under-utilized
- HUB value proposition becomes unclear

Next Steps

- | | | |
|---|-----------------------------|--|
| 1 | Steering Committee Approval | Formal approval of governance framework and intake process |
| 2 | Stakeholder Communication | Announce new requirements to all NFL departments and partners |
| 3 | Current Project Audit | Classify all active projects and retroactively document scope |
| 4 | Intake System Launch | Deploy intake form, approval workflow, and Sentrais tracking |
| 5 | First Governance Review | Schedule monthly dashboard review with Program Execution Committee |

Questions & Discussion

*Let's formalize the structure that
delivers measurable innovation outcomes*